



RUNBOOK

VIRTUAL CONTROL

VMWARE CLOUD FOUNDATION SOLUTIONS

Changing ESXi & vCenter Root Passwords in VCF 9

Changing vCenter and ESXi root passwords without breaking VCF trust — the brownfield ESXi-root gap, and the appliance-root expiry gotcha.

v1.1

VMware Cloud Foundation 9

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INTERNAL

Changing ESXi & vCenter Root Passwords in VCF 9

Prepared by: Virtual Control LLC **Date:** July 27, 2026 **Platform:** VMware Cloud Foundation 9.0.1

When to use. To change the **vCenter appliance root** and/or **ESXi host root** passwords in a VCF-managed environment **without** breaking inter-component trust. The correct path depends on **whether VCF actually manages the credential** — which is not a given on a brownfield-imported or post-redeploy environment.

1. First — Check What VCF Actually Manages

Open **VCF Operations** → **Fleet Management** → **Passwords** (SDDC Manager UI is deprecated). Note the two operations: - **Update** — *you supply* the new password; VCF sets it on the server **and** its own record (keeps them in sync). ← use this - **Rotate** — VCF auto-generates one. **Remediate** — re-syncs VCF's record *after* an out-of-band change.

Then confirm which accounts are actually present:

```
TOK=$(curl -sk -X POST https://sddc-manager.lab.local/v1/tokens -H "Content-Type: application/json" \
-d '{"username":"administrator@vsphere.local","password":"<sso-pw>"}' | python3 -c "import
sys,json;print(json.load(sys.stdin)['accessToken'])")
curl -sk -H "Authorization: Bearer $TOK" https://sddc-manager.lab.local/v1/credentials | python3 -m
json.tool
```

2. vCenter Root — VCF-Managed (the normal case)

vCenter root is listed as a **root / USER / SSH** account. 1. **Fleet Management** → **Passwords** → **mgmt** → select the **vCenter root** row → **UPDATE PASSWORD**. 2. Enter + confirm the new value → submit. 3. If rejected, it's the **password-complexity policy** — adjust and resubmit.

Doing it here keeps VCF's stored credential in sync — **an out-of-band change on the appliance would desync it** and require a **Remediate**.

3. ESXi Root — Often NOT VCF-Managed (brownfield / post-redeploy)

On a brownfield-imported or post-redeploy VCF, the credential store may hold only the `svc-vcf-esxiNN` **SERVICE** accounts and **NO ESXi root** (verified 2026-07-27). Then the Passwords UI's **"Show ESX Hosts"** toggle shows nothing — there is no VCF root record to Update.

Because VCF holds no ESXi root credential, changing it directly is safe: - vCenter manages hosts via the auto-created `vpxuser`, NOT root — so changing root does **not** disconnect the host or affect other components. - The `c-vcf-esxiNN` service account is separate and untouched.

Procedure (per host): 1. Open the **ESXi Host Client**: `https://esxiNN.lab.local/ui` 2. **Manage** → **Security & users** → **Users** → **select** `root` → **Edit user** → set + confirm the new password. 3. **Verify** (does not require vCenter): SSH in with the new password, and confirm the host is still attached to vCenter: `bash vim-cmd hostsvc/hostsummary | grep managementServerIp #` should show the vCenter IP

(2026-07-27: esxi01 root changed this way, login verified, host stayed vCenter-connected.)

3a. Appliance Root (vCenter / SDDC Manager / VCF Operations) — Expiry Gotcha

An expired appliance root password reports as "Configured password was not accepted" over SSH — it looks like a *wrong* password but isn't. A non-interactive client (`plink -batch`, scripts) can't complete the forced-change flow, so it just reports rejection. The appliance itself stays up. Verified 2026-07-27 on **vcf-ops.lab.local** (192.168.1.77).

- **Fix:** log in **interactively** (a real terminal, or the VM Web Console) — the OS forces the change: enter the expired password → set a **new** one (must meet complexity *and* differ from the expired one).
- After: `chage -l root` to see the policy; `chage -M -1 root` to disable max-age if your policy allows.
- **The VCF Operations appliance root password is separate from the lab-wide credential** and is subject to expiry — track it.

4. Notes

- If VCF *does* manage ESXi root (host appears under "Show ESX Hosts"), use **UPDATE PASSWORD** there instead of the Host Client, to keep the store in sync.
- **Confirm the host is healthy/connected before** pushing a credential change to it (especially if it's implicated in another issue).
- If any local tooling authenticates to these hosts/appliances with the old root password (scripts, monitors), **update that config** after the change.
- The brownfield ESXi-root gap is a symptom of the inventory desync — see [[RUNBOOK-SDDC-Host-Inventory-Desync-and-Sync-Inventory-Brownfield-2026-07-27]].

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Version	Date	Notes
1.0	2026-07-27	Initial runbook.
1.1	2026-07-27	Added §3a: appliance-root expiry gotcha (an expired appliance root reports as 'password not accepted' over non-interactive SSH; fix interactively) — verified on the VCF Operations appliance 2026-07-27.

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